



“Germany... is a place of dead men’s skulls... and a **field of blood.**”

EDWARD CALAMY, ENGLISH PREACHER, 1641

Defenestration of Prague

Protestants assembled in Prague’s Hradshin Castle, where they threw two Catholic regents out of a window in protest for violating guarantees of religious freedom.

Battle of White Mountain, 1620

This was the first major military encounter of the 30 Years War. The Catholic League and imperial forces had a numerical advantage over the Protestant troops, routing them in just two hours.



The 30 Years War

The Habsburg-controlled Holy Roman Empire sought to reestablish its imperial authority against an array of disparate enemies from 1618 to 1648. Initially a civil war between rival religious factions in Germany, the 30 Years War became a battle for European supremacy.

BEFORE

Religious divisions, dynastic ambition, and the impact of the Reformation << 256–59 all had a role in sowing the seeds of the 30 Years War.



HELMET OF CHARLES V, HOLY ROMAN EMPEROR

HOLY ROMAN EMPIRE

The Frankish king, Charlemagne (742–814), was the empire’s first ruler << 188–89. By the end of the 16th century the empire included much of Germany, part of the Netherlands, Bohemia (Czech Republic), and many states in Italy.

THE STRUCTURE OF GERMANY

During the Reformation, Holy Roman Emperor Charles V allowed the princes of each state within his realm to choose their state’s religion << 256–59. Many German states adopted Protestantism, causing tension within the Holy Roman Empire.

Throughout the 16th century, the Catholic Church was the only continent-wide institution in Western Europe, remaining part of the daily routine of millions of its inhabitants. But the words of Martin Luther, John Calvin, and the Reformation (see pp.256–59) had challenged the previously unquestioned authority of the pope. The result was the agreement in 1555 of the Peace of Augsburg. The Holy Roman Emperor, Charles V, along with the Imperial Diet (legislative assembly) headed by the empire’s great princes, agreed that each ruler in the empire should be able to choose between Catholicism or Lutheranism (but not Calvinism) for their realm’s religion. This gave Lutherans equal rights under the imperial constitution.

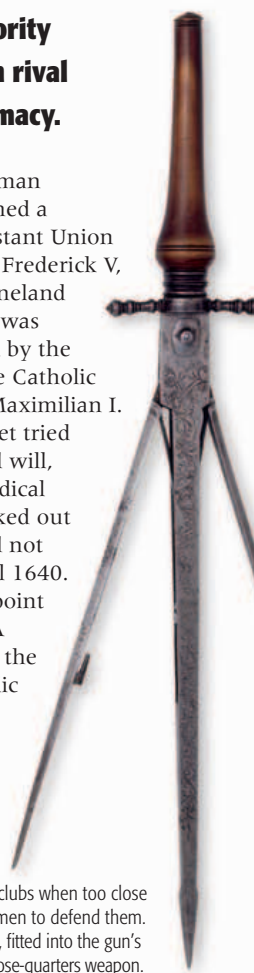
Tension still existed between Catholics and Protestants, however. In 1607 a riot between the two sides broke out in the south German city of Donauwörth. The emperor authorized Catholic Duke of Bavaria, Maximilian I, to restore order. When the duke imposed a rigorous Catholic settlement

on the city, German protestants formed a defensive Protestant Union led by Calvinist Frederick V, ruler of the Rhineland Palatinate. This was swiftly followed by the formation of the Catholic League led by Maximilian I. The Imperial Diet tried to resolve the ill will, but the more radical Protestants walked out and the Diet did not meet again until 1640.

The real flashpoint came in 1617. A Habsburg duke, the devoutly Catholic Ferdinand of Styria, was

Plug bayonet

Musketeers during the 30 Years War used their muskets as clubs when too close to fire, relying on pikemen to defend them. Later, the plug bayonet, fitted into the gun’s muzzle, was a better close-quarters weapon.



named Crown Prince and Emperor Matthias’s successor as King of Bohemia, a primarily Protestant realm. As a result of his push for a Catholic Reformation in Bohemia, Protestant nobles rebelled in 1618 with the “Defenestration of Prague” (see left). Regents representing Ferdinand

ENDEMIC WAR

The 30 Years War was a series of conflicts spurred by religious bigotry and imperial paranoia that divided Europe from 1618–48. For the people living in central Europe, this period was one of continuous warring.

